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Exploring pre-service secondary teachers' understanding of care

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ABSTRACT
Care in teaching has been widely investigated; however, little research has sought secondary pre-service teachers' understandings of caring and their potential responsibility to care for students. Accordingly, semi-structured interviews were employed with four focus groups, involving 12 (2 male and 10 female) participants. Data were analysed within a qualitative paradigm using Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) and inter-rater reliability. Five overlapping themes were identified, and although many tensions around the ambiguities of establishing appropriate boundaries to care were shown, caring was deemed central by the participants to being effective teachers. Overall, pre-service secondary teachers agreed that neither pedagogy nor discipline strategy would be effective without care. Training implications and suggestions for future research conclude this paper.

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Caring; pre-service teachers; student teachers; teacher education and teacher

In education, the concept of 'care' has been widely researched and is emerging as an important component of effective teaching (Velasquez, West, Graham, & Osguthorpe, 2013). Increasingly, teachers are required to identify and respond to the emotional and psychosocial needs of students (Onchwari, 2010). Within this contemporary context, this study explores pre-service secondary teachers' understanding of the concept of care.

In defining caring pedagogies, research indicates that the concept of caring in teaching is closely related to context and culture (Velasquez et al., 2013). Yet, despite the research and theoretical contributions to defining care in education, there is still a need to clarify and understand how teachers in different contexts and communities perceive care in teaching practice. Given that the conceptualisation of care is contextual, and will vary depending on location and educational setting, it is important to explore the notion of care in different cultural contexts and educational levels.

To date, most of the research about care in pre-service education has been conducted in the US and UK. What can be ascertained from the limited research conducted with pre-service teachers is that 'care' is viewed as a critical component and an ideal to aspire to;

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however, few studies have addressed the complex question of 'how' this might be achieved and whether and to what extent culture and grade level may influence teachers' views of caring. Velasquez and colleagues (2013) point out that certain contexts, including secondary education, need to be the focus of future research. Thus, conducting further research in a setting different from the US and UK, namely Australia, and in the secondary arena, allows for a comparative understanding about the way in which caring might be valued and promoted. A focus on secondary education may be particularly useful to teacher educators because of the salience of adolescence as a critical developmental period. Since this is the period in which young people establish future relationship patterns, their own independence and sense of identity and commonly experience anxiety about their future, both academically and socially (Wentzel, 2002), it is important to explore the ways in which pre-service teachers conceptualise their roles in relation to caring for students in secondary settings. Such an inquiry could enable researchers and educators to acknowledge potential concerns, gaps or similarities that exist across countries and settings and could have important implications for teacher education programmes and educators.

Background on research on care in education

In teaching, *caring* has been defined as those 'emotions, actions and reflections that result from a teacher's desire to motivate, help or inspire their students' (O'Connor, 2008, p. 117), a definition based on previous literature (Acker, 1995; Gilligan, 1982; Kohl, 1984; Mayeroff, 1971; Noddings, 1984, 1995; Rogers & Webb, 1991; Weinstein, 1998). Focusing on the reciprocal nature of care, a recent review concluded that 'caring pedagogy is the act that results from a symbiotic caring relation between student and teacher, in which learning happens through modelling, dialogue, practice and confirmation at the individual and community levels' (Velasquez et al., 2013, p. 182). At the same time, the nebulous nature of care and in particular, how it might be enacted in classrooms, has led to questions about the different ways the concept of care might be understood and promoted. According to Ferreira and Bosworth (2000), care must be contextualised and explored with reference to the cultural context of schools and the communities in which they are located. Culture includes students' diverse racial, ethnic and linguistic backgrounds (Gay, 2010) as well as the cultural structures established in schools, which collectively inform and shape teaching practices and a teacher's professional identity (Flores & Day, 2006).

Traditionally, education literature has defined 'care' in terms of developing personal competency (Mayeroff, 1971) and social responsibility in students (Gilligan, 1982). Similarly, Kohl (1984) also conceptualised the importance of caring in education within a moral framework stating 'a teacher has an obligation to care about every student' (p. 66). Teachers have always had a legal obligation and commitment to a 'duty of care', involving established practices of safety, custody and protection of children. However, the notion of care, as outlined in Noddings' work (1984, 1986, 2010), extends beyond the level of duty of care and incorporates the social and emotional context of caring and supportive student–teacher relationships.

Further elaborating the point about the duty of care, Fletcher-Campbell (1995) highlights a conceptual distinction of care: 'caring for' and 'caring about'. Where 'caring for' is aligned with a teacher's contractual obligation related to the 'duty of care', Fletcher-Campbell (1995) and Noddings (2010) argue that 'caring about' involves a teacher's personal beliefs and commitment, rather than externally imposed accountability. Extending these arguments,

Noddings (1999) asserts that 'caring-about' is an attitude or motive, while 'caring for' is characterised by receptivity, and thus needs to be privileged above 'caring-about' because it requires an acknowledgement from the student of being 'cared for'. The argument that caring is not only behavioural but also an ethical and decision-making process, with an intellectual component, has been reaffirmed by several recent authors (Ferreira, Smith, & Bosworth, 2002; Velasquez et al., 2013).

Similarly, Vogt's (2002) interview study, involving 32 primary teachers, concluded that care was articulated in a number of ways involving mothering and parenting as well as commitment, relatedness and, at times, physical affection. Kemp and Reupert (2012) found some ambiguity around whether primary pre-servive teachers should 'touch' students, even though most participants considered that hugging or putting an arm around the shoulders of a student was an acceptable form of caring. The issue of touch was especially challenging for male pre-service teachers, some of whom found alternative ways of caring that are less culturally 'suspect' for men (Hansen & Mulholland, 2005). This contemporary twist on the concept of 'care' that is more than a 'duty', presents challenges for teachers today, given regulatory guidelines and social expectations that prohibit physical contact between teachers and students. At the same time, teachers are seen as responsible for meeting the unique and increasingly complex psychosocial and emotional needs of their students by, for example, being responsive to cultural diversity (Gay, 2010), students' drug use and mental health concerns (Roeser, Eccles, & Sameroff, 2000) and cyber bullying (Smith et al., 2008). Additionally, broader changes in society such as the disappearance of the extended family, longer working hours, the infiltration of technology and different family types (single and blended parenting, single-sex parenting) might well have implications for the role of the teacher in relation to caring (Musgrove & Taylor, 2012). It is within this contemporary context that the current study was conducted.

Research on perspectives on care held by students and teachers

An overview of care in education research conducted over the past two decades demonstrates that most studies on pre-service preparation were located in North America and the UK, and that most of these studies examined notions of teacher care from students' perspectives as well as those of in-service and pre-service teachers (see Table 1). This research appears to describe care as a specific relational behaviour (in the student–teacher relationship) that teachers may engage in as well as a characteristic of other teaching behaviours, such as behaviour management. As can be noted in a review of Table 1, several studies have focused primarily on identifying 'caring' behaviours and attitudes from both students' (Caldwell & Sholtis, 2008; Muller, 2001; Teven, 2001) and teachers' perspectives (Aspfors & Bondas, 2013; Cooper, 2004; Hansen & Mulholland, 2005).

Student perspectives on care

In two studies examining students' perceptions of teacher caring, Teven (2001, 2007) found that the implementation of 'caring pedagogy' (that is empathy, understanding and responsiveness) increased students' perceptions of teacher competency and student engagement. Teven (2001, 2007) concluded that teachers were perceived by students as caring when they demonstrated immediacy, assertiveness and responsiveness. These studies suggest how care is communicated to students and how it is developed through student–teacher relationships.

Table 1. Summary of empirical literature on caring.

Authors and date	Methodology	Participants	Country
Student-based studies			
Bosworth (1995)	Qualitative: Interviews Observations	Secondary students	USA
Caldwell and Sholtis (2008)	Qualitative: Q methodology	Secondary students	USA
Ferreira and Bosworth (2000)	Qualitative: Interviews Observations	Secondary students	USA
Ferreira, Smith, and Bosworth (2002)	Qualitative: Interviews Observations	Secondary students	USA
Hayes et al. (1994)	Qualitative: Survey Ethnographic	Primary students	USA
Jasin (2010)	Mixed Methods: Questionnaires and interviews	Secondary students	USA
Larson (2006)	Qualitative: Critical incidence forms	Primary and secondary students	USA
Muller (2001)	Quantitative Multiple Regression	Secondary students	USA
Resnick et al. (1993)	Quantitative Discriminant Analysis	Secondary students	USA
Rogers and Webb (1991)	Qualitative: Interviews and observations	Students and in-service teachers in primary setting	USA
Teven (2001)	Quantitative: Questionnaires	Students at tertiary level	USA
Teven (2007)	Quantitative: Questionnaires	Students at tertiary level	USA
Wentzel (1997)	Quantitative	Secondary students	USA
Wentzel (2002)	Quantitative	Secondary students	USA
In-service teacher studies			
Collinson et al. (1998)	Qualitative: Survey Interviews	In-service secondary teachers	England, Ireland and USA
Noblit, Rogers, and Mc Cadden (1995)	Qualitative: Ethnographic	In-service primary teacher	USA
Acker (1995)	Qualitative: Ethnographic	In-service primary teachers	Canada
Acker and Feuerverger (1996)	Qualitative: Interviews	In-service tertiary teachers	Canada
Alder (2002)	Qualitative: Interviews Focus groups Classroom observations	In-service primary teachers	USA
Aultman et al. (2009)	Qualitative: Typology	In-service and pre-service primary teachers	USA
Barber (2002)	Qualitative: Ethnographic	In-service secondary teachers	Australia
Cooper (2004)	Qualitative: Interviews Observations	In-service teachers primary and secondary	UK
Hansen and Mulholland (2005)	Qualitative: Interviews	In-service and pre-service primary teachers	Australia
Aspfors and Bondas (2013)	Qualitative: Online questionnaire and focus groups	Newly qualified teachers	Finland
Larson and Silverman (2005)	Qualitative: Interviews	In-service primary and secondary teachers	USA

(Continued)

Table 1. (Continued)

Authors and date	Methodology	Participants	Country
McLaughlin (1991)	Qualitative Interviews	In-service primary teachers	USA
Noblit (1993)	Qualitative: Ethnographic	In-service primary teachers	USA
O'Donoghue et al. (1994)	Qualitative: Interviews Focus groups	In-service primary teachers	Australia
Vogt (2002)	Qualitative: Interviews	In-service primary teachers	UK
Pre-service teacher studies			
Goldstein and Freedman (2003)	Qualitative: E-journals	Pre-service primary teachers	USA
Goldstein and Lake (1999)	Qualitative: Dialogue journal writing	Pre-service primary teachers	USA
Goldstein and Lake (2000)	Qualitative: Dialogue journal writing	Pre-service primary teachers	USA
Goldstein and Lake (2003)	Qualitative: Dialogue journal writing	Pre-service primary teachers	USA
Goldstein (1998)	Qualitative: Case study	Pre-service primary teachers	USA
Gomez et al. (2004)	Qualitative: Case study	Pre-service secondary teachers	USA
Kemp and Reupert (2012)	Qualitative: Interviews	Pre-service primary teacher	Australia
Lee and Ravizza (2008)	Qualitative: Interviews	Pre service secondary teachers	USA
Smedley and Pepperell (2000)	Qualitative: Interviews	Male pre-service primary teachers	UK
Weinstein (1998)	Qualitative: Survey	Pre-service primary and secondary teachers	USA

Similarly, in both student- and teacher-based studies, research seems both to emphasise the importance of building caring teacher–student relationships and to show how a caring approach can influence student improvement in terms of student learning (Ferreira, 2000; Hayes, Ryan, & Zseller, 1994; Wentzel, 1997, 2002) and student behaviour (Caldwell & Sholtis, 2008; Teven, 2007). For example, Muller (2001) analysed US-based longitudinal data from surveys of year 8, 10 and 12 students and found that academic progress was high for students who felt that their teachers cared when they actively listened, when they demonstrated interest in their students and when they encouraged student success.

In-service teachers' perspectives

Another body of research has examined care in terms of how teachers teach. For example, some consider care to include an awareness of student learning styles and student background (Ferreira, 2000; Ferreira & Bosworth, 2000; Hayes et al., 1994). This work has also incorporated fair learning environments (Collinson, Killeavy, & Stephenson, 1998; Moran, 2008; O'Donoghue, Brooker, & Purdie, 1994) and respectful school communities (Aspfors & Bondas, 2013) as important components of care as understood by in-service teachers. Similarly, some have considered the notion of care when discussing the management strategies teachers might employ when disciplining students (Aultman, Williams-Johnson, & Schutz, 2009; Stoughton, 2007; Weinstein, 1998; Woodcock & Reupert, 2012).

Pre-service teachers' perspectives

Other researchers have examined care from pre-service teachers' perspective (Aultman et al., 2009; Goldstein, 1999; Goldstein & Freedman, 2003; Goldstein & Lake, 1999, 2000; Gomez, Allen, & Clinton, 2004; Kemp & Reupert, 2012; McLaughlin, 1991; Weinstein, 1998). While pre-service teachers identify caring as important in teaching, many studies report that pre-service teachers tend to hold unrealistic and idealistic notions of caring (Goldstein & Lake, 2000; Lee & Ravizza, 2008; McLaughlin, 1991; Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2011; Weinstein, 1998) or views that others considered to be incorrect or ill-informed (Velasquez et al., 2013).

In a review of literature on care in early childhood and primary teacher education programmes, McNamee, Mercurio, and Peloso (2007) found that it is critical that 'would-be' teachers learn about caring for students in teacher programmes. However, studies exploring pre-service teachers' perceptions of caring in secondary settings are limited and more research is needed to explore the concept of care as understood by this group. Findings from this study will contribute to this body of research and extend knowledge of how secondary pre-service teachers understand care within a contemporary context.

While pre-service teachers have a broad theoretical knowledge base, they are often challenged when faced with 'real' teaching situations as beginning teachers (Whitbeck, 2000). Bobek (2002) estimates that some 50% of beginning teachers leave the profession within the first year and that many report being disillusioned when responding to children's emotional needs (McCann & Johannessen, 2004). At the same time, research has highlighted the importance of a quality preparation programme (Darling-Hammond, Chung, & Frelow, 2002). Thus, notwithstanding the importance of ongoing professional development for teachers and the experiences they obtain once in the classroom, one critical period for the acquisition of teaching skills, both technical and relational, is during teacher education (Woodcock & Reupert, 2012). Thus, investigating how pre-service teachers understand their caring role and responsibilities, and their sense of how caring might be enacted, has the potential to inform future teaching programmes as well as beginning teacher support programmes.

Method

Theoretical framework

Given the exploratory nature of the study and the abstract nature of caring, a qualitative research design was chosen. Focus groups were chosen as our major research method as focus groups are useful to elicit participants' feelings, attitudes and understandings about a particular topic through conversations and interactivity (Smith & Osborn, 2008; Williams & Katz, 2001). It has been argued that focus groups are less intimidating than one-on-one interviews and, moreover, have the potential to be supportive for those in attendance (Williams & Katz, 2001).

Data were collected and interpreted using Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) in which themes and issues were sought from participants rather than predetermined hypotheses (Smith & Osborn, 2008).

Setting

The study was based at an urban Australian campus with a cohort of over 400 secondary pre-service teachers. Pre-service teachers who were undertaking either a Bachelor

of Education (four-year programme) or Graduate Diploma of Education (one-year programme) were invited to participate. Both courses are designed to provide students with knowledge of education theories, pedagogy, curriculum and assessment, as well as practices that mediate teaching and learning. Supervised professional practicums are compulsory for both courses.

Procedure

After ethical approval was obtained by the relevant committee, information about the study was distributed at the end of lectures. Focus group sessions, facilitated by the first author, were conducted where participants were provided with refreshments and encouraged to discuss the topic, 'the caring teacher', in relation to their experiences as pre-service teachers. Four focus groups were conducted, ranging between one and two hours. With participants' permission, focus groups were audio-recorded and subsequently transcribed by professional transcribers.

Participants

Convenience sampling was chosen as it allowed for the researcher to draw on the lived experiences of pre-service teachers who had prior knowledge about teaching and the teacher role. Twelve (2 male and 10 female) pre-service secondary teachers, aged 21–30 years, volunteered to participate. Teaching experience while on practicum ranged 25–55 days, according to course progression. Five participants completing the Graduate Diploma of Education were mature aged students who had previously been employed in professions such as medicine and accounting. The sample comprised of pre-service teachers from a variety of disciplines as described in Table 2. Individual contributions by participants during four focus group

Table 2. Demographic data of participants.

Practicum experience					
Focus group	Participant	Course details	School context	Specialism	Levels taught
1	F1	Graduate Diploma	Private Urban	Music	7,8,9,11,12
1	F2	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	English Humanities	7,8
1	F3	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	English History	8,9
2	F4	4th year Bachelor Education	Private Public Urban	English Mathematics	7,8,11,12
2	F5	4th year Bachelor Education	Public Private	English History	7,8,9, 10,11
2	F6	4th year Bachelor Education	Public Private	English Drama	7,9,10,11
3	F7	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	Music	7,8,9,11,2
3	F8	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	Art Drama	7,8,9, 10,11
3	F9	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	English Drama	7,8,11,12
4	M1	2nd year Bachelor Education	Public Urban	History Physical Education	7, 8, 9
4	F10	2nd year Bachelor Education	Public Urban	Science	8,9,11
4	M2	Graduate Diploma	Public Urban	Mathematics Science Information Technology	7,9,11

discussions were identified using codes that denoted gender and focus group. For example, F (Female) 1, 2, 3 … 10 and M (Male) 1, 2 (see Table 2).

Focus groups

In the four focus groups developed here, semi-structured questions based on the literature review and our research intention were used to guide group discussion. These were complemented by follow-up and probing questions designed to encourage reflective thinking at critical discussion points. For example, the first question, '*When I say the word "caring" what comes to mind?*', additional probing questions such as '*Can you give me an example of …*' or '*What do you mean by …*' were used to encourage elaboration and rich discussion. Active listening techniques were utilised throughout to encourage participant contributions. Participants were also given opportunities to challenge the perspective of other group members and elaborate on issues.

Data analysis

Transcripts were analysed according to IPA (Smith & Osborn, 2008). IPA is a qualitative approach that aims to derive meaning from participants' personal experiences rather than analyse phenomena in terms of trends and frequencies (Braun & Clarke, 2006). IPA is phenomenological as it is concerned with an individual's personal perception, as opposed to attempts to produce an objective statement of the experience (Smith & Osborn, 2008).

Analysis drew on 91 pages of transcription data. In accordance with IPA, the analysis was conducted in two stages: intra-interview analysis and across-interview analysis. At the intra-interview stage, emerging themes were documented and clustered into potential groups with attention given to the underlying meaning and not just the frequency of a theme. This data analysis stage involved reading each transcript closely a number of times, annotating significant comments in the right-hand margin. At each stage, intra-interview and across-interview analyses, themes and patterns in the data-set were identified and grouped by mapping relationships between codes and themes. An analysis was conducted by two researchers who met to discuss and reach a consensus to ensure inter-rater reliability.

Results

Five overlapping and interrelated themes were identified from the data, as summarised in Table 3 and further described below.

Enactments of care

The pre-service secondary teachers in this study defined 'caring' as enactments of care through interpersonal relationships and pedagogical practices. Initially, the pre-service teachers denoted care in the ways in which they foster relationships with students, for example, 'by showing an interest' and 'engaging with students by listening and engaging in a dialogue, talking to them' and by 'taking the time to get to know each student' personally. All found that 'knowing about their home situation' was essential for fostering relationships with students. Statements like, 'I think it means, taking an interest in the student outside of what we just see, in here in the classroom' (F1) and

Table 3. Emergent themes related to care in teaching.

Final coding framework	Initial coding framework
1. Enactments of care	Interpersonal relationships
	Pedagogical practices
	Addressing individual student needs
2. Caring and behaviour management	Boundary setting
	Mutual respect
	Care comes first
3. Boundaries around caring	Finding 'the line'
	Overstepping boundaries
	Professional role
4. Barriers to caring	Teacher workload
	Bureaucracy and other expectations
	Inexperience and inadequate skills
5. Learning to care	Other professional experience
	Mentors

> Treating everyone as an individual and really caring about each student, to know what each student is up to and knowing that, and trying to find something totally [about] each student. (F9)

seemed to encapsulate their sense of interpersonal caring.

Pre-service teachers showed they cared through their pedagogical practices. Some described caring in this way as 'setting them [students] up for success' by understanding their strengths and limitations as learners. Teacher flexibility and willingness to adjust lessons and expectations was also emphasised by many participants, for example, ' … success for one kid is not the same for another kid, and you've got to celebrate the achievements of each kid … ' (F2) or

> … putting in work and taking time to come up with ways of engaging students, not just writing questions from the textbook on a board, or whatever, and sort of caring about that they're getting it and engaging. (F3)

Other pedagogical practices that pre-service teachers aligned with caring included taking a student-oriented approach to teaching, modifying and adjusting lessons in response to student feedback, designing a variety of assessment strategies that accommodated all learning styles and negotiating extra time for assignments if students were ill or not coping due to family circumstances.

Caring in teaching for many pre-service teachers meant that they assumed the learner perspective:

> I think definitely empathise, you know remembering what it's like to be in the learning position and not having an idea about what is being taught … remembering your experiences as a learner. (F5)

Many aligned caring with a teacher's willingness to reflect and shape their practice so that student needs are prioritised:

> 'How was my lesson', because content and all that sort of stuff that comes with time, but it really is all about – just relating to [students]. (F6)

Conversely, according to those interviewed here, teachers who 'don't care' take no interest in student engagement.

> … they just sort of seemed disengaged with the students, like they never really talked to them on a personal level and I would just hear the way they talked in the staffroom, they would talk about students and it was almost always in a negative way. (M1)

Overall, it would appear that for many, enacting or demonstrating care extended beyond teaching subject matter. They described teaching the 'whole student', or, in other words, 'Most of it they're going to forget, but we need to teach them, how to get knowledge and how to function in society' (F6). Hence, acts of care involved both pedagogy and interpersonal relationships.

Caring and behaviour management

Many highlighted the tension between caring for students and managing student behaviour. First, working with students with challenging behaviours was raised. Participants shared lengthy anecdotes of experiences with 'disruptive kids' and 'disengaged kids'. Many agreed that during placement they were ' … spending too much energy on behaviour and classroom management'. Another stated:

> I had a student in a year 7 class that sort of played on my mind for the whole placement, and he was a really disruptive and loud student … when I was teaching that class, it was just so frustrating and you could feel yourself getting worked up about it and not being caring. (F2)

Subsequently, some participants expressed the 'conflict' involved in balancing care and student discipline, or, in other words, 'setting [care] boundaries':

> I don't know whether to be friendly or whether to be really strict … (F6)

> [you need to] find that balance somewhere, and I don't know, I don't know if I've figured that out yet … (F7)

For some pre-service teachers, disciplining students was challenging and a source of anxiety and tension: 'I just don't know … it's so hard … to find a nice balance'. At the same time, many identified one strategy, 'show them that you care':

> I really made an effort to use their names … Start your own relationship with them, that's just about you and that kid. (F1)

When discussing classroom management, many pre-service teachers highlighted the importance of knowing the student as a way to foster respectful relationships, e.g. 'Classroom management comes easier if they know you, and it's that mutual respect' (M1).

According to these pre-service secondary teachers, caring was demonstrated by 'respecting kids' and this was reciprocated by students who would 'give you respect back'. Moreover, respect was a key component in building trusting relationships with students:

> … what is respect, how do you get it sort of thing … it was about caring, like you have to care to get it, because that means you value respect in itself, and you have to give it … by valuing it you have to give it and receive it. (M2)

Being 'fair' to students was viewed as essential to maintaining mutual respect and a means of balancing these demands, 'so you have to try and not be unbalanced in how you treat them' (M2). For some, this notion of care was extended to giving their students 'second chances' and 'the benefit of the doubt' so that students 'had a clean slate' (F3).

Finally, most agreed that showing their students that they cared through building respectful relationships was important to managing 'disruptive', 'loud' and 'disengaged' students. The sentiment was best summed up by one pre-service teacher: '… caring is the first step, and all the other stuff, like flows from that' (F3).

Boundaries around caring

Many pre-service teachers described anxiety about 'how caring to be'. The metaphorical 'line' that divides appropriate and inappropriate caring was referred to numerous times:

> … because I want to care … [but] I want the kids to understand but at the same time I don't know where that line is drawn. I think that's my problem, where is my care line drawn? (F5)

> … the teachers who try to be their students' friends … it just never works, the students actually don't respond well to that at all, I think. They also lose respect for the teacher, so there is a fine line. (M2)

One 4th year pre-service teacher expressed her anxiety about her caring role in relation to her professional identity: 'I don't know who I am as a teacher' (F6). Conversely, all Graduate Diploma pre-service teachers queried whether they might become 'too far involved' and taking on a role beyond their level of training and expertise.

> There is such a thing as too much caring, it's when you start to get involved … if a kid has family problems … you've overstepped the boundary. (F8)

Others described the boundary ambiguities in their role as caring teachers:

> We're not social workers but we might be faced with – we probably will be faced with people that have emotional problems. (F7)

> I'm not a psychologist … we're not social workers … (F10)

For many, the boundaries were not clear which caused them frustration and anxiety about their 'professional responsibility as a teacher'. One participant highlighted the following contradiction:

> I definitely find the whole teaching as a profession thing really warped … you're dealing with real people, I mean I guess I think of … profession as business … we're there for the learning and then we do the best we can but you're dealing with the whole person. (F10)

Thus, the metaphorical 'line' of how much or little to care in their teaching role was an issue for many of the pre-service teachers interviewed here.

Barriers to caring for students

Inexperience in teaching adolescents was identified as one barrier to care:

> I find that I'm not at that level yet where I'm reading my classroom effectively … where I can get that deep sense of analysis of who is really engaged … especially with, invisible kids, the kid that never says anything. (F6)

Meeting the competing demands of different stakeholders was the other barrier to caring, for example: 'the biggest pressure for me about caring is catering to the stakeholders, the parents, the other teachers and ultimately, the people above you' (F5). Other barriers included class sizes, time and teacher workload, 'it's hard to [care] with a school that's got 200 kids in one year level, you know' (F6).

Some described prioritising their caring attention, in which 'the students' needs' came first:

> It's those things [extra demands] that make me not care about the stakeholders … [but] It doesn't make me stop caring about it at the student level … [but when it comes to] all that bureaucratic administration stuff, I don't really care. (F4)

Learning about caring

When participants were invited to reflect on their development as teachers, the majority explained that their course did not include notions of care. Whether care was discussed during university training was dependent on individual tutors: '… he just decided to do it one day, it wasn't part of that unit … that was pretty useful but if I wasn't in his class, I wouldn't have got it' (M2).

Others attributed their attitudes to caring from experiences and professions held before training to be a teacher, as one female pre-service teacher indicated: 'So, I was a doctor before I came and did teaching, so that was covered a lot in our course, and so, I've got that kind of experience to draw on' (F1).

Opportunities to observe mentors, and other teachers during practicum, was highly valued as a way of learning to care.

> [She, the mentor, is constantly] thinking about the kids … they really can see that about her, you can tell that they know that she cares about them … you can tell the kids really like her and respect her. (F2)

Thus, past experiences and role models contributed to attitudes to caring rather than coursework.

Discussion

The secondary pre-service teachers interviewed here perceive their caring teaching role as multifaceted with many interrelated themes. The various themes relate to each other in various ways, in which an acknowledgement of, and sensitivity to, the 'whole' student appeared to be central. Participants described care in terms of specific behaviours as well as the way in which they taught and managed students' behaviour. For the secondary pre-service teachers interviewed here, caring was the 'first step', a notion which subsequently infused how they taught and built relationships with students. The reciprocal nature of caring was inherent in many of these discussions, or in the words of one of those interviewed, 'you have to care to get it … by valuing it you have to give it and receive it'. Notwithstanding the importance of care, many also alluded to the boundaries of caring for students, and concerns regarding 'overcaring' or becoming too involved.

Participants found it easiest to describe caring in terms of specific behaviours or enactments and indicated that care is demonstrated via interpersonal skills when fostering relationships with students and through effective pedagogy. Based on their practicum experiences, pre-service teachers identified the interplay between curriculum, student discipline and caring, with the majority indicating that neither pedagogical nor disciplinary strategy would be effective without care. Thus, whilst many barriers to care were identified, and many acknowledged the lack of training in this area, caring for students was a crucial component to being effective teachers.

Many of the results here are consistent with previous research conducted in other settings. For example, student-based studies primarily conducted in the US have identified caring teachers as those who show empathy and concern for students' personal lives (Alder, 2002; Caldwell & Sholtis, 2008; Ferreira & Bosworth, 2000; Muller, 2001; Rogers & Webb, 1991), similar to those descriptors provided by pre-service secondary teachers here. Conversely, non-caring teachers were identified as those who were 'disengaged' and 'not interested' in

teaching or students. Thus, it would appear that both students and pre-service teachers, across different settings (albeit Western), have similar notions about the importance of supportive and individualised interpersonal relationships between teachers and students.

In addition, the secondary pre-service teachers here described the centrality of care in teaching, aligning notions of care with maximising student learning and personal growth. Moreover, pre-service teachers in the present study described care as fundamental to successful behaviour management rather than caring and discipline being distinct entities. These findings seem to contradict one study in the US by Weinstein (1998) that reported secondary pre-service teachers dichotomised the notion of care from pedagogy and classroom control; in that study, care was perceived as different from maintaining order in the classroom, whereby achieving 'order' was aligned with 'being mean' and 'caring' was associated with 'wanting to be nice' (p. 161). Further studies are required to ascertain whether the differences here can be attributed to different teacher educational systems (including school placement experiences) and/or the contextual factors inherent in the respective school systems.

Moreover, teaching the 'whole' student was a prominent theme in this study. According to the pre-service secondary teachers interviewed, genuine care is enacted by being 'sensitive' to individual needs and by acknowledging students when doing their best, given their developmental level and life circumstances. In essence, caring teachers were those who provide opportunities for personal success by taking the time to find out about students as learners, where they come from and 'who they are as people'. This meant knowing students as learners as well as 'people'. For these pre-service teachers, teaching encompassed more than the subject matter taught in classes. The role of a caring teacher is implicit in helping develop the whole person beyond the classroom so that students have skills that enable them to function in society and develop as well-rounded 'human beings'.

Educational policy and research repeatedly emphasise the importance of teaching in a holistic manner (Ferreira & Bosworth, 2000; Resnick, Harris, & Blum, 1993). It is significant that pre-service teachers here also acknowledge the importance of this, given its importance generally in teaching. Of concern are the tensions pre-service teachers report around caring too much and whether they might step over 'the line'. How to teach the whole child while at the same time not 'cross the line' has important training implications for both pre-service and beginning teachers. For instance, pre-service teachers might require guidance in terms of when and how to refer students on to other professionals, in a sensitive manner. Knowing how much or little to give and acknowledging that a student might have needs greater than what a teacher can realistically or ethically fulfil are issues that need to be reflected on whilst training because as in the words of one participant 'we are not social workers'. These training gaps resonate with previous studies conducted with primary pre-service teachers in North America and the UK (Goldstein, 1999; Goldstein & Freedman, 2003; Goldstein & Lake, 1999, 2000; Weinstein, 1998).

Effective pedagogical practices were a crucial way in which care was shown to students. Past research drawn from students' and teachers' perspectives found democratic and inclusive approaches to teaching improved student engagement and student learning (Acker, 1995; Alder, 2002; Bosworth, 1995; Caldwell & Sholtis, 2008; Collinson et al., 1998; Ferreira, 2000; Ferreira & Bosworth, 2000; Goldstein & Lake, 2000; Noddings, 1995; O'Connor, 2008; Resnick et al., 1993; Rogers & Webb, 1991). Similarly, in this study, many pre-service teachers demonstrated care via their teaching and assessment practices, underpinned by

their individualised knowledge of the student. In other words, good teaching is equated to caring teaching.

In addition, care was considered important to successful learning, discipline and behaviour management. While some pre-service teachers struggled with the day-to-day behavioural issues inherent in teaching adolescents, the majority articulated a deeper, complex understanding of the interrelationship that exists in enacting care, pedagogy and classroom discipline. The notion of 'students and teachers working together' promoted and encouraged reciprocal relationships characterised by trust and respectful student–teacher relationships. Widely discussed during the focus groups, many participants were concerned about 'overstepping the boundary' by 'being too friendly' or becoming 'too involved'. Similarly, Aultman et al. (2009) highlight the ambiguity and complexity of negotiating boundaries in caring student–teacher relationships.

Likewise, some pre-service teachers identified conflict between their desire to care for their students and maintain control of the classroom. From their perspective, they were spending a disproportionate amount of time and energy dealing with behaviour and classroom management issues during their practicum. However, most argued that by maintaining a 'human' connection and 'personal' presence, they were in a better position to engage students in their learning, and address discipline issues.

Pre-service teachers interviewed highlighted that, in their experience, caring was not a central component of coursework and a forum for discussion about the complexity of enacting care was notably absent. Pre-service teachers indicated that inexperience and inadequate training limited their ability to enact care during their practicum. Instead, learning to care, according to the pre-service teachers interviewed, was the result of prior professions and mentors during practicum (both caring and non-caring). Overall, participants agreed that while 'being a caring teacher' was an ideal to aspire to, most felt they 'haven't figured that out yet'. As Goldstein and colleagues (1999, 2000, 2003) noted, pre-service teachers' understanding of care can be an ideal starting point for productive, educative dialogue about the development of caring teacher practice. In this study, participants highlight the important role of practicum supervisors in how notions of care might be discussed and modelled during teacher preparation.

The results have important implications for teacher education programmes. The profession of teaching has a long-time commitment to 'duty of care', around established practices of safety, custody and protection. However, many participants in this study expressed concern about their lack of training in meeting the challenges they are likely to face when they practice 'care' in their teaching. Based on the previous literature as well as participants' experiences and conceptions of care documented here, there are several ways in which pre-service teachers might be encouraged to consider what caring for students might mean for them as soon-to-be teachers. One possible method is to introduce case studies for analysis and reflection based on discussion points that highlight the everyday ethical dilemmas that can be potentially faced by novice teachers (Richert, 2011) into new or existing subjects, a suggestion made by some participants. Unlike other professions, such as medicine, law and psychology, ethics is typically not included in teacher education programmes (Campbell, 1997; White & Taft, 2004). Another suggestion might be to introduce ethically orientated decision-making models into the content material of teacher education courses. Ethical decision-making models could potentially provide a framework for pre-service teachers and practicum supervisors to discuss and reflect on caring boundaries in the context of

teaching, especially in terms of how teachers might relate to students who are experiencing problems at home (which participants considered to be a potentially problematic area), or in relation to contentious areas, for example, responding to students who initiate a hug or another form of touching. Additionally, the role of practicum supervisors is important in facilitating the professional development of pre-service teachers, particularly in addressing caring boundary issues in the immediacy of teaching actions and within the context of the classroom or playground.

Modelling, dialogue, practice and confirmation (Noddings, 1984) might be general activities embedded in subjects to consider what a caring stance means and how it might be enacted, for example, through readings, role playing, case studies, observations and discussion groups. Similarly, given the importance participants placed on placement experiences for learning about care, pre-service teachers might be asked to conduct research on their own and their supervisor's caring practices and invited to reflect how caring might be enacted by different people, in different contexts and with different students; this process may mediate theory and practice and prompt students to recognise that caring is an individual, nuanced and evolving process. Similarly, Velasquez and colleagues (2013) suggest that pre-service teachers could reflect on moral dilemmas they have experienced with students and the implications this has on caring pedagogy and the teacher–student relationship. Time needs to be built into teaching courses to discuss the ambiguities involved in caring for students, so pre-service teachers have the opportunity to reflect on what they see during practicum, and reflect on what this means for practice, ethically and professionally. Moreover, it needs to be pointed out that caring is a broader issue than the pre-service teacher alone and does not exist in a vacuum; teachers who care tend to be associated with caring school communities where relationships and responsibilities are given priority over rights and rules (Velasquez et al., 2013). Similarly, care needs to be modelled implicitly and explicitly by university staff in terms of what is said and done in their own teaching practices. We cannot expect students to care for students unless we model it in our own practice as teaching professionals (Reupert, 2009).

The process of referring to other professionals (when, how and who) is another training need identified by participants in this study. Interestingly, pre-service teachers did not describe working with parents, especially for at-risk students. Collaboratively working with others (including parents, other teachers and school staff) is a critical skill that all teachers need to acquire and subsequently needs to be actively taught in teacher training programmes. Moreover, the participants in the current study are right to state that they are not psychologists or social workers and, by implication, cannot be expected to assume a role that involves treating students' social and emotional difficulties. However, several studies have pointed out that teachers should have the skills to identify students who are at risk and to be able to gently refer such youth on to the appropriate welfare staff (Phillippo & Kelly, 2014; Reupert & Maybery, 2007). Being able to identify at-risk students is intimately associated with knowing the 'whole student', an attribute that pre-service teachers described as being core to caring for students, though a skill that is continually evolving over a teacher's career.

Conclusion

The experiences of the secondary pre-service teachers in this study cannot be seen as representative of all secondary pre-service teachers; the sample size was small and drawn from one urban

university, with pre-service teachers working in similar cultural contexts. Most of the sample is female. However, the study does not aim for generalisation (Smith & Osborn, 2008), rather it was designed to yield rich and deep data regarding the experiences of a self-nominated group of pre-service teachers within a certain time and place. Given the small sample size, the results of this study create an opportunity to test themes further through a larger-scale study. More specifically, findings may be used to develop instruments to measure care in teaching environments, in order to produce generalisable outcomes. It is also important to emphasise that this study relied on self-report data and future studies might incorporate observations of teaching in order to ascertain how pre-service teachers demonstrate care in their classrooms, while on placement and as beginning teachers. How these understandings and corresponding behaviours might change over time as pre-service teachers gain more experience and in different situations (that is, different classrooms, schools, age of students and so on) might also be ascertained. As the cultural context of research such as this is important, future studies might also be conducted in developing nations.

In conclusion, this study explored pre-service secondary teachers' understanding of the concept of care. The results showed that within an Australian teaching and learning context 'care' was valued among these pre-service secondary teachers. However, results identified student tensions around discipline, boundary issues as well as anxiety about decision-making when faced with various caring dilemmas. Furthermore, the findings revealed that these anxieties were underpinned by concerns about the limited training in this area. Therefore, the study has important implications about how 'care' is promoted, discussed and modelled in education programmes.

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